
8. Develop a regular shopping circuit

By this, I mean those favorite few stores that are on your regular path for errand running, as well as the occasional stop at a mega-savings store that is worth your while to hit once every four to six weeks. It's a good idea if your shopping circuit includes a few thrift and secondhand stores, as well as discount retailers and grocery warehouses.

If you have a few extra minutes anyway, stopping by a place that's on your way to check out a seasonal pocketbook or blazer doesn't cost you a ton of extra gas or time. It doesn't mean you should stop in and shop just for the sake of shopping. But if you know you'll have a need for a particular item in the next few months, it pays to start casually shopping in advance for a great price. This will also give you a sense of what the regular prices are, how often a particular hard-to-find item becomes available, and when you've found a deal you are not likely to see again.

9. Calculate your ROI

Your ROI is your return on investment. This can apply to larger retirement investments as well as money-saving

items you are considering as purchases. For example, if you think a food processor is going to save you money, figure out how much money you can easily save each month through its use and divide that into the full price of the item. After that return is reached, you are looking at pure extra cash on a regular basis. This extra cash can be used for fun, travel, savings, investing, or anything else you feel fits into your "living large" goals.

10. Get excited about percentage rate savings

When I see someone who regularly turns their nose up at 10% savings opportunities, I am seeing someone who could probably retire much earlier than they actually will. They are avoiding a savings percentage rate they would most likely be thrilled to receive on a liquid savings account or CD. When you decide you need a brand name of a particular item like a baking spice, and it costs \$1.20 versus \$1.00 for the store-brand equivalent, you are choosing a fairly large percentage difference.

These smaller types of decisions add up, especially on items we buy regularly. The example I used is a small one. Let's go a bit higher and apply it to something like new blinds for the house. If you could pay \$1,000